

HiveForce Labs

THREAT ADVISORY



ACTOR REPORT

Mustang Panda APT targets Europe with customized PlugX malware

Date of Publication

January 07, 2023

Admiralty code

A1

TA Number

TA2023066

Summary

First Appearance: 2019

Actor Name: Mustang Panda APT(Bronze President ,TEMP.Hex ,HoneyMyte,Red Lich,Earth Preta)

Target Region: Asia and Europe

Target Sectors: Government and public sector industries



Actor Map



Actor Details

#1

The Mustang Panda APT group has been targeting government and public sector organizations across Asia and Europe since at least 2019 with cyberespionage campaigns that align with the strategic interests of the Chinese government.

#2

Recently, the group has shifted from using archive files to using malicious optical disc image (ISO) files to deliver a modified version of the PlugX malware, increasing the group's evasion against anti-malware solutions targeting Europe. The group employs a four-stage infection chain that leverages malicious shortcut (LNK) files and DLL search-order-hijacking to load the PlugX malware into the memory of legitimate software.

#3

The malware is delivered via an ISO image attachment in an email and is disguised as a Word document to trick the user into thinking there is no malicious activity. The PlugX malware loader uses a simple XOR algorithm to decrypt the encrypted shellcode, avoiding detection by antimalware solutions.



Actor Group

NAME	ORIGIN	TARGET REGIONS	TARGET INDUSTRIES
Mustang Panda APT(Bronze President ,TEMP.Hex ,HoneyMyte,Red Lich,Earth Preta)	China	Asia and Europe	Government and Public sectors
	MOTIVE		
	Information theft and espionage		

Recommendations



Security Leaders

Phishing simulations and routine education and awareness training and communications rarely account for MFA fatigue and web browser hygiene. Integrate and communicate all lessons learned.



Security Engineers

- **Uni5 Users:** This is an actionable threat advisory in HivePro Uni5. Prioritize and block all indicators attributed to the threat actor through your Command Center. Test your controls with Uni5’s Breach & Attack Simulation.
- **All Engineers:** Refer to and action upon the ‘Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs’ & ‘Indicators of Compromise (IoC)’ on the following pages.

Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs

<u>TA0002</u> Execution	<u>TA0005</u> Defense Evasion	<u>TA0011</u> Command and Control	<u>TA0003</u> Persistence
<u>T1204.002</u> User Execution: Malicious File	<u>T1574.001</u> Hijack Execution Flow DLL Search Order Hijacking	<u>T1036.007</u> Masquerading: Double File Extension	<u>T1140</u> Deobfuscate/Decode Files or Information
<u>T1566.001</u> Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment	<u>T1566.002</u> Phishing: Spearphishing Link	<u>T1573.001</u> Encrypted Channe: Symmetric Cryptography	<u>T1132.001</u> Data Encoding Standard Encoding
<u>T1204.001</u> User Execution: Malicious Link	<u>T1547.001</u> Boot or Logon Autostart Execution: Registry Run Keys / Startup Folder	<u>T1027.002</u> Obfuscated Files or Information: Software Packing	<u>T1055</u> Process Injection

✂ Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

TYPE	VALUE
SHA 256	ee2c8909089f53aafc421d9853c01856b0a9015eba12aa0382e98417d28aef3f 8c4926dd32204b6a666b274a78ccfb16fe84bbd7d6bc218a5310970c4c5d9450 723d804cfc334cad788f86c39c7fb58b42f452a72191f7f39400cf05d980b4f3 2c0273394cda1b07680913edd70d3438a098bb4468f16eebf2f50d060cdf4e96 26c855264896db95ed46e502f2d318e5f2ad25b59bdc47bd7ffe92646102ae0d
IPV4	217[.]12[.]206[.]116 45[.]134[.]83[.]29

✂ References

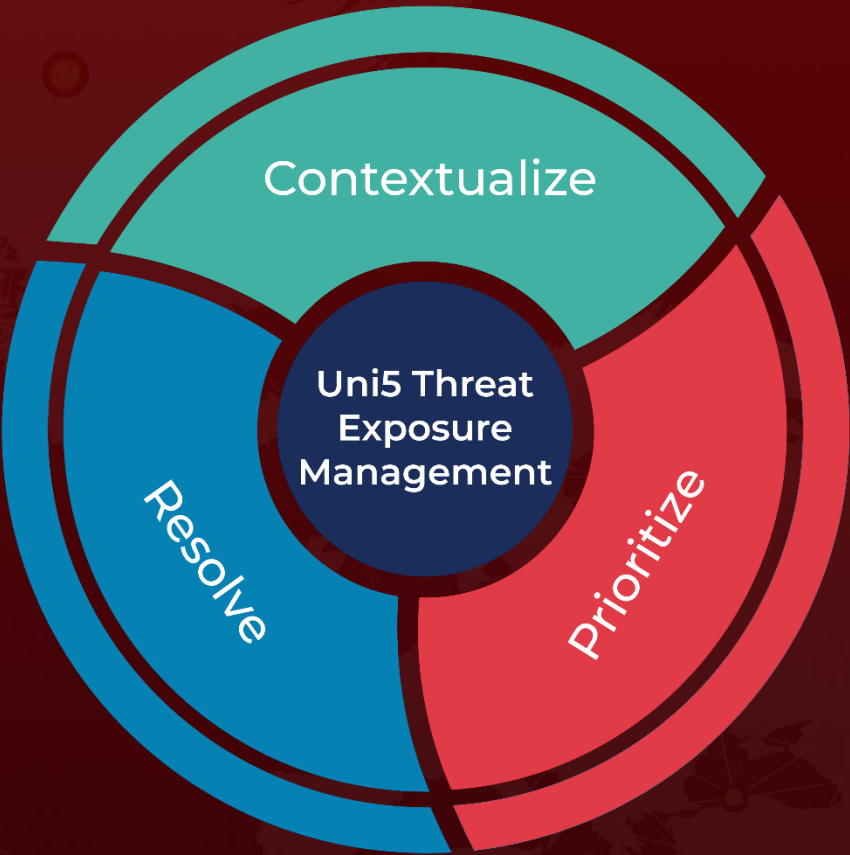
<https://blog.eclecticiq.com/mustang-panda-apt-group-uses-european-commission-themed-lure-to-deliver-plugx-malware>

<https://www.hivepro.com/mustang-panda-targets-european-diplomats-using-enhanced-plugx-backdoor/#:~:text=Mustang%20Panda%2C%20a%20Chinese%20cyberespionage,the%20ongoing%20conflict%20in%20Ukraine>

What Next?

At Hive Pro, it is our mission to detect the most likely threats to your organization and to help you prevent them from happening.

Book a free demo with HivePro Uni5: Threat Exposure Management Platform.



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